## 13.5 Policy enforcement points in the stack

The request flow in Figure 13.2 shows what happens when a single authorization is evaluated. In practice, C³ enforces policies at multiple points within its infrastructure. Each Policy Enforcement Point (PEP) functions at a different scope, but all share the same purpose: to standardize requests into the PARC structure and evaluate them through the appropriate PDP. Collectively, they create a distributed enforcement network that covers the entire C³ platform.

### 13.5.1 Global enforcement: the ACME Gateway

At the outer edge of the platform, global enforcement is managed using the ACME Gateway, a distributed network of ingress and API gateways that collectively serve as the platform's global PEP. Instead of a single choke point, the gateway layer consists of multiple regional clusters deployed near customer data to minimize latency. Each gateway enforces identical policies and follows the same evaluation workflow.

When a request enters C³—whether from an ACME employee, a customer tenant, or an automated integration—it first arrives at the gateway in its closest region. The gateway carries out four coordinated steps:

1. **Authenticate and verify tokens**. It validates OIDC tokens for all callers and posture tokens for ACME employees, caching trusted issuers and keys for improved performance.
2. **Resolve tenant context**. It identifies the target tenant using the token's `tenant_id` claim and directs the request to that tenant's namespace.
3. **Evaluate global policy**. It calls the C³ PDP to apply platform-wide governance policies such as tenant isolation, rate limits, data residency, and device compliance for ACME staff.
4. **Normalize and forward**. If the global decision is `permit`, the gateway generates a normalized PARC request and forwards it to the tenant's PEP for ReBAC evaluation.

Because gateways function as a coordinated mesh, policy decisions and tenant resolution remain consistent across regions. Each gateway stores